

Before Capital: Labour, Debt, and the Foundations of Economic Thought in Classical Athens by A.W.C. van Beek

1 Turning Point Between Historical Modes of Production



Modern political economy often treats Smith, Mill, and Marx as inaugurating the conceptual vocabulary through which labour, property, and value are analysed. Yet the categories they inherit have deep prehistories. To understand how capitalism becomes possible, Marx argues, one must examine the succession of historical forms that precede it: primitive communism, the slave mode of production, and feudalism; these modes aren't isolated stages but historical transitions, each preparing the structural conditions for the next.¹

Classical Athens occupies a unique position within this sequence. It is the first society to develop a fully articulated slave mode of production grounded in legal ownership of persons, sophisticated institutional forms, and explicit philosophical justification. At the same time, it generates contradictions, especially around landholding, monetary expansion, and class struggle, that destabilise the slave mode from within and prepare the terrain for emerging feudal structures in the later Hellenistic and Roman worlds. Athens was therefore not merely "another slave society" but the transformational hinge between two major historical epochs.

From this vantage point, Classical Athens practices illuminate how central economic concepts such as labour, property, unfreedom, value, and accumulation form long before they are theorised. Labour becomes stratified into hierarchies that anticipate later struggles over productivity and dignity. Alienation appears in its most absolute form, revealing what is at stake when Marx later analyses the condition of the wage-worker. Primitive accumulation begins not with capitalist expansion but with the restructuring of land, the rise of monetisation, and the dissolution of communal property.

Thus, beginning the genealogy in Classical Athens is not a backward extension of modern categories but a recognition that Athens stood at the threshold where the slave mode reached its fullest expression and began its transformation into new institutional and economic forms. The argument of this essay is that Classical Athens, possibly extended to Classical Greece, constitutes a necessary historical precondition for feudal and later capitalist development, and must therefore be included in any comprehensive genealogy of global capital.

2 Labour Division and the Slave Mode of Production

Classical Athens organised its population into sharply bounded labour categories that reveal how economic roles were grounded in political exclusion rather than productive function. Citizens (i.e., free adult males) held full political rights, property ownership, and access to the institutions of the Polis. Metics, although often economically indispensable as traders, craftsmen, or financiers, could never cross the boundary into citizenship. As Vernant observes,

Between a metic and a citizen, both in charge of a manufacturing establishment with 15 or 20 slaves, or active in maritime commerce, or dealing bottomry loans, there was no difference in economic status, i.e. in their position in the process of production. Nevertheless, it would be impossible to consider them members of the same class.²

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¹ Marx (1859), [pp. 11–13](#)

² Vernant (1976), [p. 75](#)

Class identity in Athens was determined not by one's position in the productive process, but by civic honour and juridical standing. Women, though born into citizen households, were entirely excluded from political life and confined to domestic labour. Slaves, by far the largest labouring group, formed the indispensable productive base of the Polis, sustaining agriculture, mining and quarrying, manufacturing, commerce, banking, civil service (e.g., clerks, policemen, prison attendants), and domestic service.³ Labour in Athens was therefore not understood as a universal human activity, but as a condition defining the unfree. However, Finley argues that "no one seriously believes that slaves did all the work in Athens"⁴ and there were always free men engaged in productive labour.⁵

3 Greek Forms of Unfreedom and Marxian Alienation

For Marx, alienation has four dimensions: estrangement from the product of labour, from the labour activity itself, from nature, and from other human beings. In the *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts*⁶ he develops these with reference to the modern wage worker, but Classical Athenian slavery offers an even clearer historical paradigm. The Athenian slave had no claim to what he produced, no control over the labour process, no recognised place in the political community, and no secure relation to his own body or to nature. Aristotle's description of the slave as a "living tool"⁷ crystallises this logic: the slave is an instrument whose very capacities belong to another.

Seen through Marx's notion of species-being⁸, this amounts to a systematic mutilation of humanity. Species-being is realised when humans engage in conscious, creative, socially mediated labour, shaping both nature and themselves in common. The slave is denied precisely this: his work serves only the master's ends; his creativity is appropriated; his social world is defined by command rather than mutual recognition. He lives inside a human world that he helps to build but cannot claim as his own. Classical Athenian slavery thus prefigures Marx's theory by showing alienation not as a psychological state but as a social structure. In Marx's sequence of historical forms from primitive communism through the slave mode to feudalism and capitalism the Polis represents a mature slave society in which alienation is direct, legal, and total.

Athenian unfreedom was not confined to chattel slavery. Before Solon's reforms, free Athenians could fall into debt bondage, family members, and eventually their own freedom when loans could not be repaid, however, land was still inalienable. Here economic compulsion and legal status intersect: a citizen may remain nominally free yet become de facto unfree through debt. Solon's *Seisachtheia* removed the most extreme form of this practice, but did not undo the underlying inequalities that kept poorer citizens dependent on creditor elites.

Foucault's analysis of early money clarifies why this form of alienation appears so early in Greek history. Coinage emerges within systems of punishment, tribute, and assessment rather than as neutral lubricant of exchange.⁹ Money measures fines, taxes, and obligations; it translates social hierarchy into quantified debt. In the Polis, this meant that land, labour, and even bodies could be drawn into a monetary logic that stabilised relations of domination.

³ Finley (1959), pp. 99–101

⁴ Ibid., p. 102

⁶ Marx (1844), pp. 28–35

⁷ Vernant (1976), p. 77

⁸ Marx (1844), pp. 31–32

⁹ Foucault (1971), pp. 138–140

The poor become indebted, the indebted become dependent, and dependence shades into political exclusion. Marx's thesis that economic relations generate legal and philosophic (e.g., moral) forms¹⁰ becomes very concrete here: Greek monetary practice already binds obligation, status, and coercion into a single institutional framework.

Chapter 2 showed how the labour of women, metics, and slaves sustained the Polis while remaining outside its political body. From a Marxian perspective, this exclusion is itself a form of alienation from species-being, as discussed earlier, because the capacity for conscious, collective self-determination is reserved for a minority. Only adult male citizens deliberate, legislate, and judge. The majority who materially reproduce the Polis are structurally prevented from appearing as political subjects. They produce the world but do not own it to interpret Marx's theory of Estranged Labour.¹¹ Classical Athenian democracy thus established freedom for the few, necessity for the many.

The Athenian household intensifies this pattern at a smaller scale. Citizen women are confined to the Oikos and charged with preserving harmony rather than shaping public life. As discussed earlier, Perictione I describes a woman's task as enduring everything from her husband: infidelity, anger, even cruelty, so that the household remains unified.¹² Her practical authority is real, since she manages resources and directs servants, but it does not translate into civic recognition. She organises production while remaining invisible to the Polis, separated from the sphere where collective decisions are made.

For enslaved members of the household this alienation becomes absolute. Their labour, time, and bodily capacities are entirely appropriated. When enslaved women breastfeed the children of their masters, even their intimate relation to nature and reproduction is reoriented toward the needs of the citizen family. They are incorporated into the household yet excluded from kinship, citizenship, and public speech. Estrangement from product, activity, nature, others, and from their own potential as conscious producers is complete.

Together, these arrangements show how thoroughly alienation permeated Athenian social life long before capitalism. The Polis and the Oikos operate as nested structures that separate those who produce from those who decide, those who labour from those who are free. In Marx's long arc from primitive communism via slave society to feudalism and capitalism, Athens occupied a decisive transitional position: it consolidated the slave mode of production and, through its evolving property relations, monetary practices, and hierarchies of status, preparing the ground on which feudal and capitalist forms of alienation could arise.

4 Landholding and Structural Preconditions of Transition

In Ancient Athens, the transformation of landholding marks a decisive structural shift within the slave mode of production, one that prepares the ground for later historical transitions rather than capitalism itself. What Marx would later call "primitive accumulation" must here be understood not as the birth of capitalism, but as the internal reorganisation of property relations that intensified exploitation, monetisation, and class differentiation in the Polis.

As Vernant¹³ shows, the Greek city-state rested on a dual system of land ownership: state land, originally communal, and private land, initially granted through mechanisms of state

¹⁰ Marx (1859), p. 12

¹¹ Marx (1844), pp. 28–35

¹² Waithe (1987), pp. 32–35

¹³ Vernant (1976), pp. 70–71

appropriation. The balance between these two forms was unstable. Over time, private landholding expanded at the expense of communal control, consolidating property in the hands of citizen elites. This shift was not incidental but structurally necessary for the development of slavery, money, and class conflict. The Polis thus became an institutional system that guaranteed exclusive access to land for a privileged minority of citizens, defining political status through property ownership.

Crucially, private property itself was internally divided. Ancestral land within the Oikos remained inalienable, belonging to the household rather than the individual and protected from free sale. Alongside this sphere, however, emerged areas where land could be bought, sold, mortgaged, and granted more freely. The coexistence of inalienable household land and increasingly commodified land generated persistent tensions that fuelled political struggles. As Vernant notes, early class conflicts in the Polis were rooted primarily in disputes over land tenure.¹⁴ Control over land was simultaneously an economic resource, a political qualification, and a marker of civic identity.

This transformation is illuminated by the Greek distinction between *oikonomia* and *chrēmatistikē*. *Oikonomia* referred to the management of the household oriented toward sustenance and reproduction; *chrēmatistikē* denoted the pursuit of wealth for its own sake.¹⁵ As land was gradually drawn into the monetary sphere, it moved from *oikonomia* into *chrēmatistikē*. By the late Archaic Period, land could even be granted to non-citizens as a reward for services, signalling a decisive loosening of earlier restrictions.¹⁶ Land ceased to function solely as the material basis of household stability and became a vehicle for accumulation, indebtedness, and dependency.

This process did not abolish slavery but deepened its integration into a monetised and stratified social order. Concentrated landownership expanded the demand for enslaved labour¹⁷, while those excluded from land were pushed toward dependence, debt, or subordination. In Marx's historical framework, this represents a mature slave society approaching its internal limits. The increasing abstraction of property, the separation of production from the household, and the growing role of monetary relations foreshadow the conditions under which direct ownership of persons would eventually give way to domination through land, obligation, and hierarchy characteristic of feudalism.

Thus, the Athenian transformation of landholding does not inaugurate capitalism but performs a crucial historical function. It destabilises the slave mode of production from within and constructs the socio-legal architecture through which later modes of domination become possible. In this sense, Ancient Athens operates as a historical transformer: consolidating slavery while simultaneously generating the contradictions that make its supersession conceivable.

5 From Direct Domination to Structural Dependence

In Marx's historical schema, the slave mode of production is defined by direct, personal, and juridically explicit domination. Human beings are owned as productive instruments. Feudalism, by contrast, reorganises domination around land rather than persons. The cru-

¹⁴ Vernant (1976), p. 70

¹⁵ Ibid., p. 72

¹⁶ Ibid., pp. 73–74

¹⁷ Ibid., p. 70

cial question, therefore, is how a civilisation such as the Polis, which perfected large-scale slavery, could nevertheless generate the internal tensions that make the later transition to feudal relations historically possible.

The answer lies in the contradictions of the Athenian Polis itself. As shown by Vernant, the gradual consolidation of private landholding at the expense of communal and state land reshaped the economic and political foundations of the city-state.¹⁸ Although slavery remained the dominant productive relation, land increasingly became the decisive bearer of status, wealth, and political authority. This shift did not abolish slavery, but it displaced its centrality. Power came to be mediated less through direct ownership of persons and more through control of territory, debt, and access to land.

At the level of the forces of production, however, the slave system reached a structural impasse. Technology remained strikingly primitive precisely because the basic productive force was human slave labour.¹⁹ There was little incentive to invest in mechanisation or technical innovation when output could be increased simply by acquiring more slaves. Yet this strategy contained its own limits. As slavery spread, resistance also increased, not in the form of organised political struggle, but as constant friction within production itself: reluctance to work, sabotage, flight, and inefficiency; it was even advised slave owners not to purchase slaves from the same country, as they spoke the same language, lest they conspire together, a telling indication of how fragile control actually was beneath the surface.²⁰

Crucially, the opposition between slaves and masters never emerged as the principal contradiction at the level of social and political struggle. Slaves did not act as a unified class intervening in the conflicts of the Polis.²¹ This is not accidental. As the earlier mentioned formulation of Aristotle: the slave being a “living tool” makes clear, the Greek conception of humanity was inseparable from political participation. To be human was to be a citizen; to be outside the Polis was to be outside society and therefore outside humanity itself.²² Slaves possessed no recognised social identity beyond their function as instruments of production. This ideological exclusion explains why slave resistance rarely took the form of systemic challenge. Revolts were individual, episodic, or escapist rather than transformative. The aim was to flee enslavement, not to restructure society.

From a Marxist perspective, this absence of collective uprising is not paradoxical. Marx is explicit that if workers are compelled, by the force of circumstances, to unite in the contest with the owning class, being crucial to revolt against a system of inequality, it will sweep away by force the old conditions of production, and thereby, ironically, abolish its own supremacy as class.²³ As Marx states “It is not the consciousness of men that determines their existence, but, on the contrary, their social existence determines their consciousness”.²⁴ Ancient slaves lacked the structural conditions for recognising themselves as a class. Their fragmentation by origin, language, function, and legal status further inhibited collective identity. Finley, rightfully, refrains from applying a strict Marxist class analysis as there was no class consciousnesses yet, illustrating the point just made, instead adopting a more Weberian

¹⁸ Vernant (1976), pp. 70–74

¹⁹ Ibid., p. 75

²⁰ Finley (1959), pp. 109–110

²¹ Vernant (1976), pp. 76–77

²² Ibid., p. 77

²³ Marx and Engels (1888), p. 27

²⁴ Marx (1859), pp. 11–12

framework focused on status, meaning, and belief.²⁵

Nevertheless, this does not mean that the slave–master relation was historically insignificant. Vernant shows that the fundamental contradiction of the slave mode of production ultimately operated at the level of productivity itself.²⁶ As slavery expanded, output encountered diminishing returns. Multiplying slaves indefinitely threatened social stability, while resistance within production imposed tighter limits on growth. To overcome this stagnation, alternative mechanisms of control became necessary. One such mechanism was the partial monetisation of labour and the introduction of incentives.²⁷ Slaves were often described as “lazy” unless threatened by violence. Paying or granting conditional privileges to dependent labourers created proto-feudal relations in which coercion was softened but not abolished. Capitalism would later intensify this logic further: labour becomes “free”, yet survival itself becomes the coercive mechanism “work or starve”.

In this sense, Classical Athens functions as a historical relay, it does not produce feudalism directly, but it exhausts the slave mode of production and generates the structural pressures that make land-based dependency, tenancy, and indirect domination increasingly viable. Slavery persists, but its capacity to drive expansion declines. The contradiction between productivity and domination can no longer be resolved within the slave system itself.

Thus, Classical Athens stands not merely as a slave society but as the transitional matrix through which the logic of feudal domination becomes thinkable. It marks the moment when direct ownership of persons reaches its historical limits, and indirect domination through land, obligation, and economic dependence begins to take shape. Without this transformation, the later emergence of feudalism and, eventually, capitalism cannot be understood genealogically.

6 Conclusion: Ancient Greece as a Structural Turning Point in the Historical Succession of Modes of Production

This essay has approached Classical Athens not as the cultural origin of Western rationality, but as a decisive structural moment in the historical succession of modes of production outlined by Marx. Situated beyond primitive communism and prior to feudalism, the Polis represents the first fully articulated slave society, one in which domination becomes institutional, property becomes political, and labour is systematically separated from freedom. Classical Athens, or Greece in more general, therefore occupies a pivotal position in the long transformation that ultimately makes capitalism conceivable.

Several conclusions follow from this genealogical perspective:

First, the Classical Athenian world demonstrates that freedom has never existed without an outside. Athenian democracy was founded on exclusion: slaves, women, and metics sustained the material life of the Polis while remaining structurally barred from political participation. Freedom appeared not as a universal condition but as a privilege made possible by unfreedom. This pattern does not disappear with the end of slavery; it reappears in transformed guise in later historical systems. The Athenian case thus anticipates a recurring logic in the history of political economy: every regime of freedom constructs its margins.

²⁵ Finley (1959), pp. 111–115

²⁶ Vernant (1976), pp. 77–78

²⁷ Finley (1959), pp. 109–110

Second, Classical Athens reveals that labour is not naturally valued but historically constituted. Labour in the Polis was despised precisely because it was associated with necessity and unfreedom. The later elevation of labour as the source of wealth, as articulated by Smith²⁸, becomes intelligible only once labour is detached from legal bondage and reorganised under feudal and capitalist relations. Classical Athenian society therefore exposes the contingency of modern economic categories by showing their absence: labour is divided, organised, and exploited, yet never theorised as productive value in its own right.

Third, Athenian slavery offers the clearest historical paradigm of alienation. Long before capitalist wage labour, the Athenian slave embodies total estrangement: from product, from activity, from political community, from nature, and from species-being itself. Alienation here is juridical and visible rather than abstract and mediated. Capitalism universalises alienation while masking it behind formal freedom; the Athenian slave society exposes its structure in its most explicit form.

Fourth, the transformation of landholding within the Polis marks the beginning of a deeper historical shift. As communal land gives way to consolidated private property and land enters the monetary sphere, the slave mode of production is intensified yet simultaneously destabilised. The growing importance of land, debt, and monetary obligation gradually displaces direct ownership of persons as the primary axis of domination. This process does not produce feudalism, but it constructs the conditions under which feudal relations become thinkable.

Finally, the limits of the slave mode of production emerge with clarity in Classical Athens. Reliance on human labour blocked technological development, while the absence of class consciousness among slaves prevented systemic transformation from below. As class consciousness requires formal freedom and universalised labour markets conditions absent in antiquity. Finley's Weberian emphasis on status and meaning is therefore historically appropriate. Yet this absence of political revolt does not negate the system's contradictions. Resistance operated at the level of production itself, where inefficiency, coercion, and stagnation exposed the exhaustion of slavery as a productive system.

Classical Athens thus appears not as an origin myth but as a historical transformer as it consolidates the slave mode of production while generating the internal pressures that push history toward feudal domination and, much later, capitalism. To understand global capital and its governance today, one must begin here, where domination becomes structural, property becomes institutional, and the long march of capital quietly begins.

²⁸ Smith (1776), p. 50: "Labour, therefore, is the real measure of the exchangeable value of all commodities".

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